

Week 1 · Day 5 · IAM & Account Security Setup

Create Your First IAM User & Lock Down the Root Account

 Time

55 min

 Objective

Create an IAM admin user with MFA, create an IAM group with AdministratorAccess, add your user to the group, and disable root account access keys.

 Prerequisites — Complete Before Starting

AWS Free Tier account · MFA app on phone (Google Authenticator or Authy)

 Portfolio Goal — What You Will Post

Add an 'AWS Security Setup' entry to your GitHub portfolio or LinkedIn — this shows employers you understand the first step of any real AWS deployment.

Lab Steps

Step 1 Navigate to IAM

1. Sign in to the AWS console using your ROOT account (email + password + MFA).
2. Search for IAM in the top search bar. Click on IAM.
3. Note the Security recommendations section on the IAM dashboard. It will list items to fix — this is your checklist.

Step 2 Create an IAM Admin Group

1. In the IAM left sidebar, click User groups → Create group.
2. Group name: Administrators
3. In the Attach permissions policies section, search for AdministratorAccess and check the box.
4. Click Create group.

Step 3 Create Your IAM Admin User

1. In the IAM left sidebar, click Users → Create user.
2. Username: admin-yourname (e.g. admin-daniel)
3. Check: Provide user access to the AWS Management Console.
4. Select: I want to create an IAM user.
5. Set a custom password. Check: Users must create a new password at next sign-in (optional).
6. On the next screen, select: Add user to group → select Administrators group.
7. Complete creation. IMPORTANT: Download the CSV with credentials — save it securely.

Step 4 Enable MFA on Your IAM User

1. Click on your new IAM user → Security credentials tab.
2. Under Multi-factor authentication, click Assign MFA device.
3. Choose Authenticator app. Scan with Google Authenticator / Authy.
4. Enter two consecutive codes. Click Add MFA.

Step 5 Sign In as Your IAM User

1. On the IAM dashboard, find your Account ID (top-right or IAM dashboard). Note the 12-digit number.
2. Sign out from the root account.
3. Sign in at: <https://<account-id>.signin.aws.amazon.com/console> OR via the IAM sign-in URL shown on the IAM dashboard.
4. Use your IAM username and password. Enter MFA code when prompted.
5. You are now operating as your IAM user — NOT root. This is correct practice.

Step 6 Verify Root Account Security

1. Sign back in as root one more time.
2. Go to IAM → Security recommendations. Verify: Root MFA is enabled, Root has no access keys.
3. If root access keys exist: Click Manage → Delete. Root should NEVER have access keys.
4. The Security recommendations panel should show green checkmarks.



Screenshot Checklist

Take these screenshots and save them to your portfolio folder:

- ☐ IAM dashboard showing your Administrators group
- ☐ Your new IAM user listed with MFA assigned

- ☐ Console sign-in as IAM user (account name shown top-right should be your IAM username)
- ☐ IAM Security recommendations showing green/resolved items

Portfolio Post — Copy & Customise

GitHub README or LinkedIn post: 'AWS Security Best Practice #1: Never use the root account for daily work. Today I created a dedicated IAM admin user with MFA, following the principle of least privilege from Day 1. #AWSsecurity #IAM #CloudBestPractices'

Bonus Challenge — Push Your Skills Further

Create a second IAM user with ReadOnlyAccess (not AdministratorAccess). Sign in as that user and try to create an S3 bucket — confirm it is denied. Screenshot the Access Denied message.

Lab Complete — Mark Off Your Progress

Lab Steps Completed	☐
All Screenshots Taken	☐
Portfolio Artifact Posted	☐
Bonus Challenge Attempted	☐